

A Study in Scarlet

Part II: *The Country of the Saints*

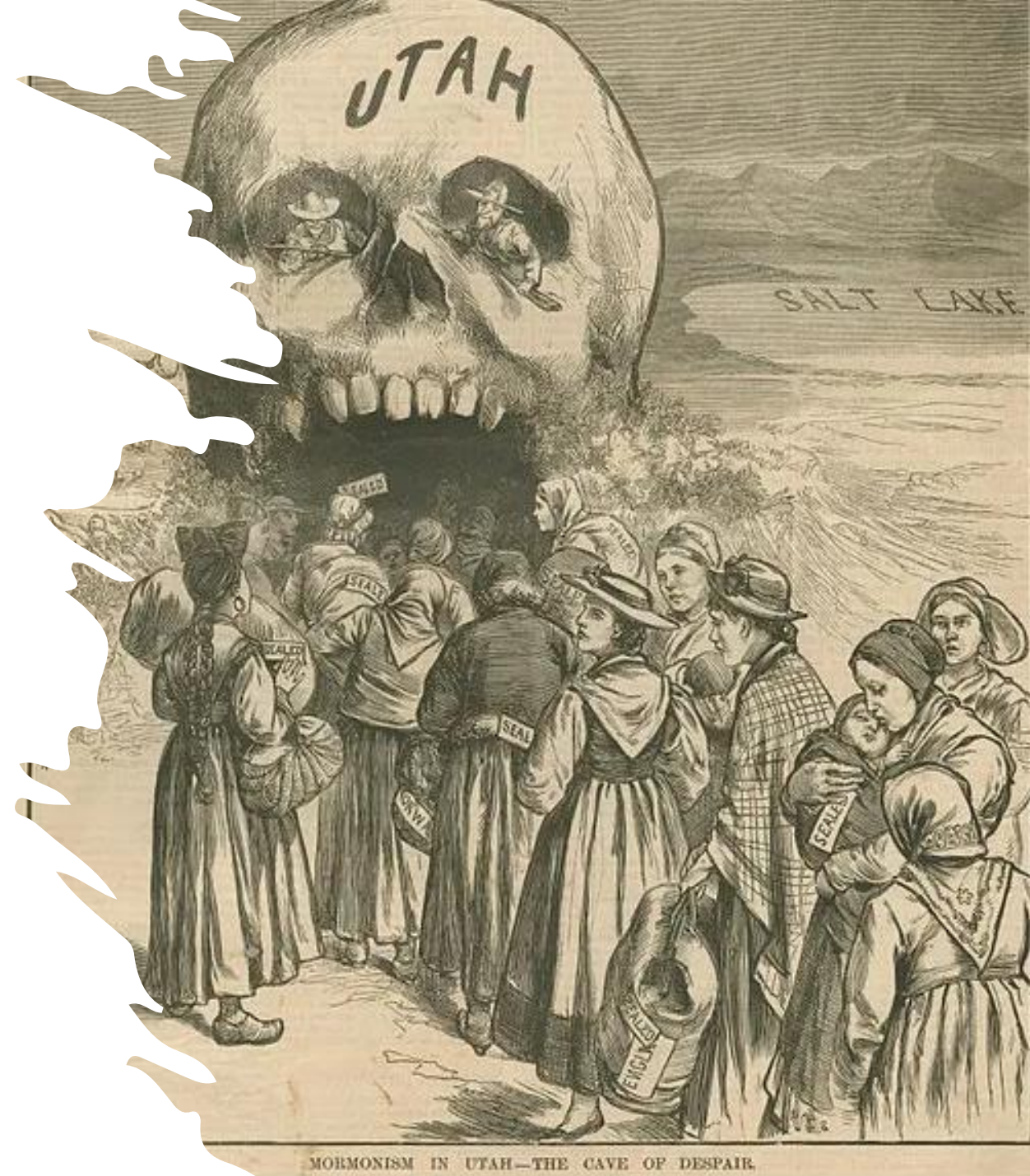


The Country of the Saints

1. Mormon Mythos
2. Surveillance and Gothic Mormonism
3. Imperial Gothic



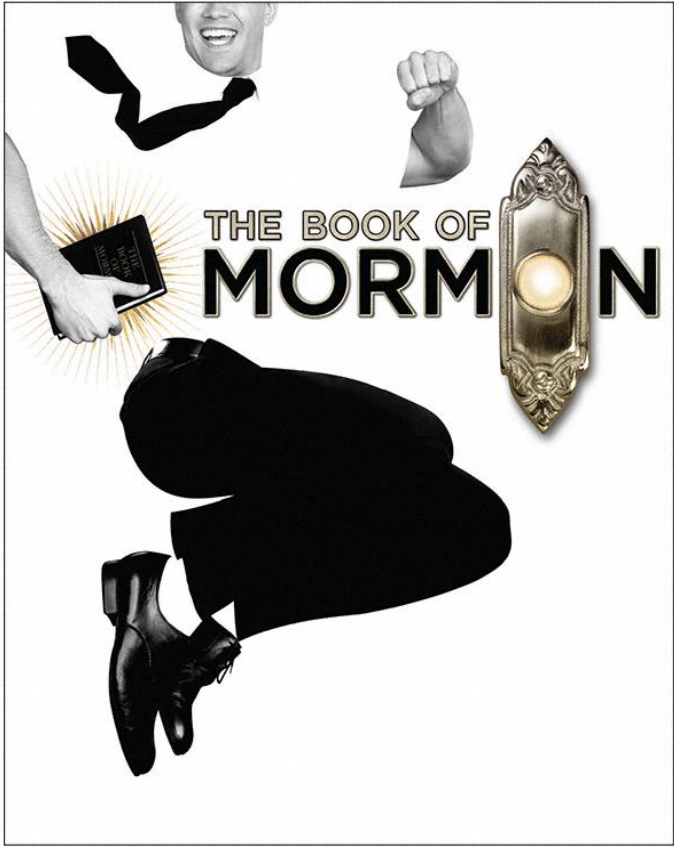
I. Mormon Mythos





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EUGENE O'NEILL THEATRE





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THE SECRET LIVES OF
MORMON WIVES





Ruby & Jodi

A CULT OF SIN
AND INFLUENCE



“A novel with a Mormon setting was well suited to the requirement of any one of the major sub-genres of the nineteenth-century popular novel. . . . For gothic preferences, the motifs of pursuit and banditry were well supplied by the Danites; the oversized, gloomy gothic setting was of course the Nauvoo or Salt Lake Temple, or in some instances the caves and canyons of Utah; abduction and imprisonment, secret rites and priestly orders—all these hallmarks of gothic fantasy the Mormons could provide in splendid abundance” (103).

—Karen Lynn, “Sensational Virtue: Nineteenth-Century Mormon Fiction and American Popular Taste”

Mormon Origins: “*The American Religion*”

- 1820: Joseph Smith’s First Vision
- 1830: Joseph Smith publishes *The Book of Mormon: Another Testament of Jesus Christ*
- 1844: Joseph Smith murdered in Illinois
- 1847: Mormon pioneers organize emigration westward in search of “religious freedom”



Doyle: “The Saint Paul of Spiritualism”

- As early as 1887, Doyle was attending Spiritualist seances and harbored curiosity about the spirit world
- It was around this time that Doyle also investigated Mormonism—though he quickly disregarded it for being too strongly aligned with the dogmas of Catholicism
- Visited Utah nearly 40 years after publication of *A Study in Scarlet* during a series of lectures promoting Spiritualism

“I could not find anywhere the least trace of persecution, and a fine spirit of tolerance was shown in many things. The most personal instance was that the Mormon Church had allowed me to speak in their Tabernacle. . . . It was the more magnanimous because in my early days I had written in *A Study in Scarlet* a rather sensational and overcoloured picture of the Danite episodes which formed a passing stain in the early history of Utah. This could have been easily brought up to prejudice opinion against me, but as a matter of fact no allusion was made to it save by one Gentile doctor, who wrote and urged me to make some public apology. This of course I could not do, as the facts were true enough, though there were many reasons which might extenuate them.”

Doyle, “The Mormons” in *Our Second American Adventure* (1924)

Joseph Smith: Prophet, Seer, Medium

“Instead of being a message of hope and knowledge for the whole human race such as we bring by Spiritualism, it is tending toward the discredited and old-world idea of a special priestly caste, of formal sacraments, and of a new sect, complete in itself and antagonistic to the other sects

I believe . . . that Smith was a true medium, but that his controls were not always reliable, nor did he have sufficient character to check them as they should be checked.”

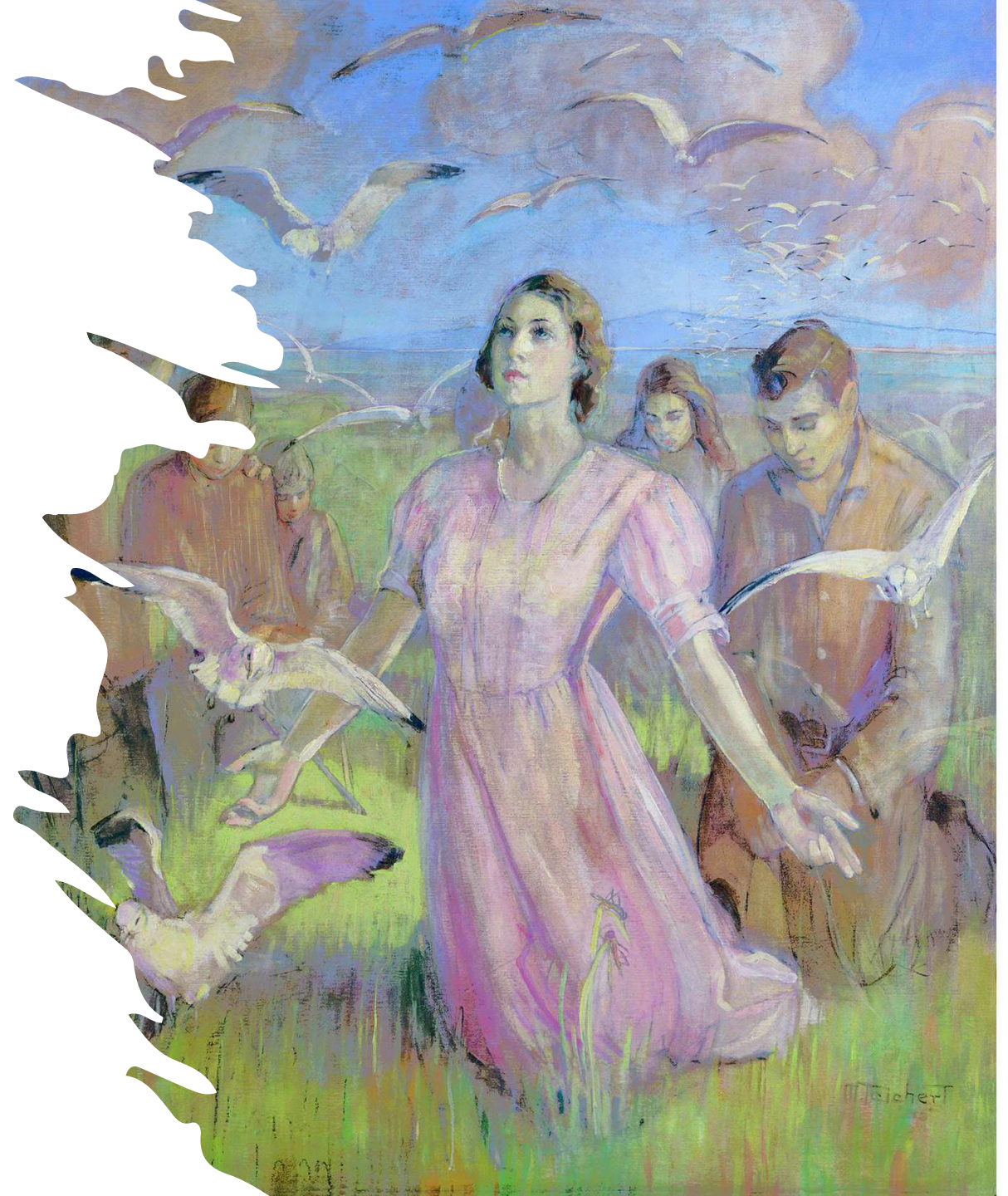
—Doyle, “The Mormons” in *Our Second American Adventure* (1924)

II. Surveillance and Gothic Mormonism



“He had always determined, deep down in his resolute heart, that nothing would ever induce him to allow his daughter to wed a Mormon. Such a marriage he regarded as no marriage at all, but as a shame and a disgrace. Whatever he might think of the Mormon doctrines, upon that one point he was inflexible. He had to seal his mouth on the subject, however, for to express an unorthodox opinion was a dangerous matter in those days in the Land of the Saints” (88).

“... bud blossomed into a flower, and the year which saw her father the richest of the farmers left her as fair a specimen of American girlhood as could be found in the whole Pacific slope” (83).



“It was a warm June morning, and the Latter Day Saints were as busy as bees whose hive they have chosen for their emblem. In the fields and in the streets rose the same hum of human industry. Down the dusty high roads defiled long streams of heavily-laden mules, all heading to the west, for the gold fever had broken out in California, and the overland route lay through the city of the Elect. There, too, were droves of sheep and bullocks coming in from the outlying pasture lands, and trains of tired immigrants, men and horses equally weary of their interminable journey. Through all this motley assemblage, **threading** her way with the skill of an accomplished rider, there galloped Lucy Ferrier, her fair face flushed with the exercise and her long chestnut hair floating out behind her... The travel-stained adventurers gazed after her in astonishment, and even the unemotional Indians, journeying in with their peltries, relaxed their accustomed stoicism as they marveled at the beauty of the pale-faced maiden” (83-84).

A historical photograph of the interior of a Panopticon prison. The image shows a large, circular central hall with a high, vaulted glass and steel roof. In the center of the hall stands a multi-story observation tower with a glass-enclosed upper section. Surrounding the central hall are several concentric tiers of prison cells, each with a small window facing the center. The architecture is designed for constant surveillance. The text "Foucault, Surveillance, and Panoptic Control" is overlaid in white on the image.

Foucault, Surveillance, and Panoptic Control

“The victims of persecution had now turned persecutors on their own account and persecutors of the most terrible description. Not the Inquisition of Seville, nor the German *Vehmgericht*, nor the Secret Societies of Italy, were every able to put a more formidable machinery in motion than that which cast a cloud over the State of Utah.

Its invisibility, and the mystery which was attached to it, made this organization doubly terrible. It appeared to be omniscient and omnipotent, and yet was neither seen nor heard” (88).

“No doubt you think that you are complimenting me in comparing me to Dupin,” he observed. “Now, in my opinion, Dupin was a very inferior fellow. That trick of his of breaking in on his friends’ thoughts with an apropos remark after a quarter of an hour’s silence is really very showy and superficial. He had some analytical genius, no doubt; but he was by no means such a phenomenon as Poe appeared to imagine” (22).

“Poe’s famous tale ‘The Man of the Crowd’ is something like the X-ray picture of a detective story . . . he always remains in the middle of the crowd. This unknown man is the flaneur . . . To Poe the flaneur was, above all, someone who does not feel comfortable in his own company. That is why he seeks out the crowd; the reason why he hides in it is probably close at hand. Poe purposely blurs the difference between the asocial person and the flâneur” (Benjamin, *Arcades Project*, 48).



CATHOLICS and MORMONS ARE DEPICTED AS FOREIGN THREATS on the U.S. CAPITOL DOME in THIS THOMAS NAST CARTOON FROM the 1870s. IT'S FORGOTTEN THAT FOR ITS FIRST

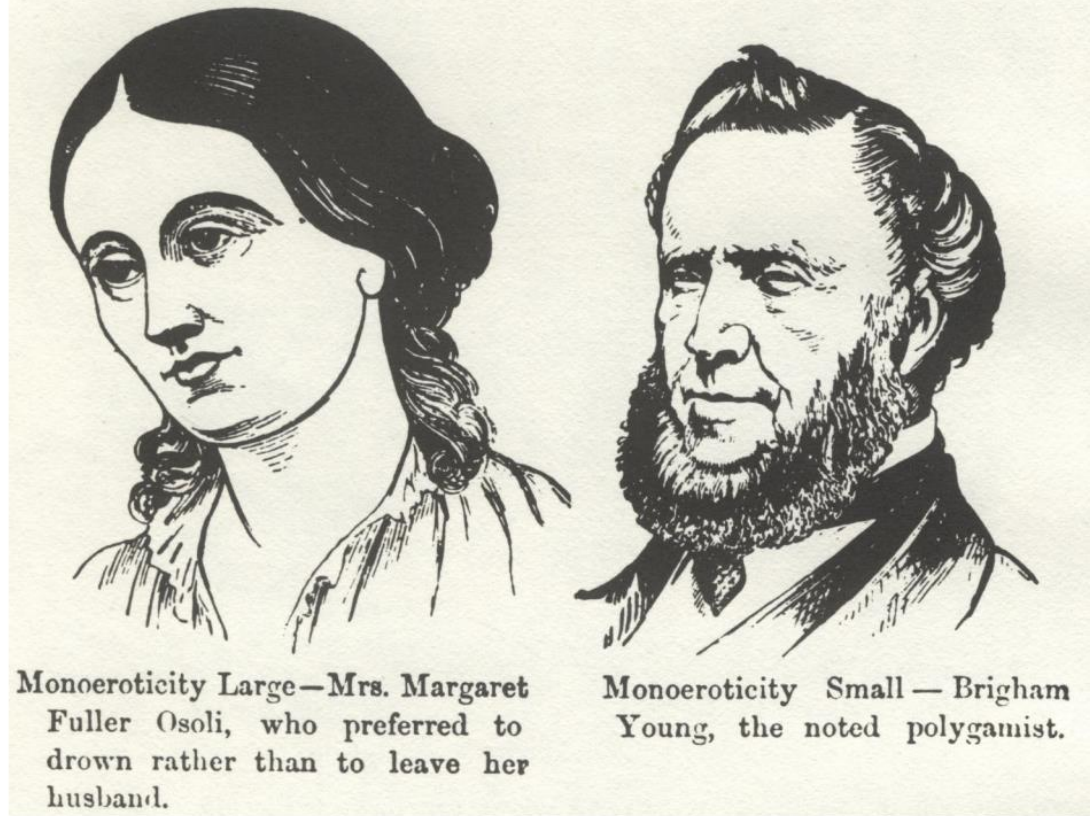
III. Imperial Gothic

“The public. . . have lost a sensational treat through the sudden death of the man Hope, who was suspected of the murder of Mr Enoch Drebbler and of Mr Joseph Stangerson. The details of the case will probably be never known now, though we are informed upon good authority that the crime was the result of an old-standing and romantic feud, in which love and Mormonism bore a part. It seems that both the victims belonged, in their younger days, to the Latter Day Saints, and Hope, the deceased prisoner, hails also from Salt Lake City. If the case has had no other effect, it, at least, brings out in the most striking manner the efficiency of our detective police force, and will serve as a lesson to all foreigners that they will do wisely to settle their feuds at home, and not carry them on to British soil” (126)

MONOEROTICITY.—MONOGAMY

THE DISPOSITION TO LOVE ONE ONLY.

The dove or round shape of the eye openings is the most unexceptionable evidence of large mating love.



Monoeroticity Large—Mrs. Margaret Fuller Osoli, who preferred to drown rather than to leave her husband.

Monoeroticity Small — Brigham Young, the noted polygamist.

Watson's description of Enoch Drebbler:

“This malignant and terrible contortion, combined with the low forehead, blunt nose, and prognathous jaw, gave the dead man a singularly simious and ape-like appearance, which was increased by his writhing, unnatural posture” (30).

Harems

“The supply of adult women was running short, and polygamy without a female population on which to draw was a barren doctrine indeed. Strange rumours began to be bandied about—rumours of murdered immigrants and rifled camps in regions where Indians had never been seen. Fresh women appeared in the harems of the Elders—women who pined and wept, and bore upon their faces the traces of an unextinguishable horror.”